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Land Deal Checklist

Know what a lot can really become before you buy it.

Rules differ by county and city. Treat every item as something to confirm in writing with the local planning, zoning, or utility office, and with a qualified professional where noted.

1. Zoning and future land use

- [ ] Current zoning confirmed with the county or city planning office.
- [ ] Future land use designation checked. It can limit what you are allowed to build.
- [ ] Allowed uses confirmed for your plan (single family, duplex, townhomes, etc.).
- [ ] Setbacks, height limits, lot coverage, and minimum lot size noted.
- [ ] Any overlay districts, historic rules, or special restrictions identified.

2. Lot split, teardown, and redevelopment

- [ ] Minimum lot size and width confirmed for each new lot if you plan to split.
- [ ] Process and timeline for a lot split or replat confirmed with the planning office.
- [ ] If a teardown: demolition permit requirements, utility disconnects, and any asbestos or hazardous material rules confirmed.
- [ ] Existing structures on the lot checked for permits, liens, and code issues.
- [ ] Impact or connection fees that may apply to new construction asked about.

3. Access and utilities

- [ ] Legal road access confirmed (public road or recorded easement).
- [ ] Water: city or county connection available, or well needed.
- [ ] Sewer: connection available and at what distance, or septic needed.
- [ ] Septic and well feasibility confirmed with the health department if applicable.
- [ ] Electric and other utilities available at the lot line.
- [ ] Cost and timeline to bring utilities to the lot asked for in writing.

4. Site conditions

- [ ] Flood zone and base flood elevation checked for the exact parcel.
- [ ] Wetlands, conservation areas, or protected trees checked.
- [ ] Drainage and low spots walked after rain if possible.
- [ ] Soil and fill needs considered. Ask a builder or engineer about the site.

- [ ] Survey ordered, and boundaries, easements, and encroachments reviewed.

5. Title and ownership

- [ ] Title search ordered and reviewed.
- [ ] Recorded easements, liens, and deed restrictions reviewed.
- [ ] Back taxes, special assessments, and code liens checked.
- [ ] Any HOA or community rules that restrict building confirmed.

6. Know your numbers

- [ ] Purchase price plus closing costs.
- [ ] Due diligence costs: survey, soil work, engineering, permits.
- [ ] Utility and site work estimates.
- [ ] Construction estimate from a builder, not a guess.
- [ ] Carrying costs: taxes, insurance, interest, mowing and upkeep.
- [ ] Finished value supported by recent comparable sales.
- [ ] Exit chosen: build and sell, build and hold, or resell the lot.

7. Red flags to slow down for

- [ ] No clear legal access to the lot.
- [ ] Zoning or land use does not match your plan and the seller says it will be fine.
- [ ] Utilities are far away or not available.
- [ ] Flood, wetlands, or drainage problems the seller does not want to discuss.
- [ ] Title issues or easements that cross the buildable area.
- [ ] Rules were explained to you only by word of mouth and not in writing.

Next step: Looking at a specific lot? Send Tony the parcel and he can help you think through the questions above.
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Tony Damiano, REALTOR. eXp Realty (TopListing Group). Florida License SL3542002. Serving Hillsborough, Pasco, Pinellas, Hernando, and Polk counties. This checklist is general education only and is not legal, tax, or financial advice. Rules and costs vary by property, county, and city, so confirm details with the appropriate office or a qualified professional. Equal Housing Opportunity.